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The legitimation of OECD's global educational governance: examining PISA and AHELO test production

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Although international student assessments and the role of international organisations (IOs) in governing education via an evidence-based educational policy discourse are of growing interest to educational researchers, few have explored the complex ways in which an IO, such as the OECD, gains considerable influence in governing education during the early stages of test production. Drawing on a comparative analysis of the production of two international tests – the Programme for International Student Assessment (PISA) and the Assessment of Higher Education Learning Outcomes (AHELO) – we show how the OECD legitimises its power, and expertise, and defines 'what counts' in education. The OECD deploys three mechanisms of educational governance: (1) building on past OECD successes; (2) assembling knowledge capacity; and (3) deploying bureaucratic resources. We argue that the early stages of test production by IOs are significant sites in which the global governance of education is legitimated and enacted.

Introduction

Educational scholars have increasingly recognised the growing influence of international comparative student assessments in the global governance of education (Meyer and Benavot 2013; Rizvi and Lingard 2010; Sellar and Lingard 2013). By governance, we refer to the act or process of governing that is not simply bounded by the nation state, but involves multiple actors and scales (i.e. global, national and local) in the policy production and implementation process (Rizvi and Lingard 2010). Grek and Ozga, for example, point to various modes of 'soft governance' such as data flows, indicators and benchmarks (2010, 938). Others have recognised that international organisations (IOs) have contributed to the construction of educational indicators and to the diffusion of an evidence-based education culture which legitimises the use of comparative data as a policy tool for governing education (Henry et al. 2001; Pereyra, Kotthoff, and Cowen 2011). Alongside the increased involvement of IOs in shaping the educational policy debate and setting the policy agenda, policy makers have come to rely on comparative data to inform educational reform. In the process, political authority in education has shifted from the national to the supranational arena (Beech 2009; Lingard and Rawolle 2011).

Although scholars have examined processes of educational governance and some have studied the mechanisms deployed in these processes by IOs (Martens and Jakobi 2010; Rutkowski 2007), they have not closely examined such practices

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during the early stages of the design of student assessments by IOs. Most have analysed educational governance by focusing on the impact of the final assessment tool at the national level (Beech 2006; Steiner-Khamsi 2003). Despite a flurry of book-length publications on the Programme of International Student Assessment (PISA) (e.g. Meyer and Benavot 2013; Morgan 2009; Pereyra, Kotthoff, and Cowen 2011) and a few journal articles on the International Assessment of Higher Education Learning Outcomes (AHELO) (Coates and Richardson 2011; Ewell 2012; Shahjahan 2013), we lack a thorough understanding of the complex ways in which the OECD enacts governance during the production of its assessment tools. By focusing on the stages of assessment production, we gain insight into IOs' governance processes, such as techniques to instil certain forms of knowledge or to transfer educational practices from the supranational to the national, deployed as the assessment is being built. Once the assessment is built, evaluation policies and practices have already been transferred by the IO to the participating country. Close attention to the process and techniques through which IOs construct tests can enhance our understanding of how IOs acquire the legitimate power to define what counts in education.

Building on the existing studies of international assessment tools, we ask how IOs establish their legitimate power and expertise during the initial production stages of AHELO and PISA. We will demonstrate that the OECD gains considerable influence in governing education as it deploys three mechanisms of educational governance to inform what counts in education. These mechanisms, each embodying a set of complex practices and processes, include: (1) building on past successes; (2) assembling knowledge capacity; and (3) deploying bureaucratic resources.

We begin by providing a brief overview of the OECD, and PISA and AHELO, its international assessment initiatives. Drawing on sociological institutionalism and the policy transfer literature, we elaborate the three mechanisms of educational governance deployed by the OECD. Employing comparative analysis, we then trace how each of these mechanisms is deployed by the OECD during the production stages of PISA and AHELO. We conclude by pointing to similarities and differences between PISA and AHELO and highlighting the ways in which each distinctively contributes to the growth in OECD influence in the global educational governance arena.

Brief overview of the OECD and its international assessment tools

The OECD is simultaneously 'a geographical entity, an organizational structure, a policy-making forum, and a network of policy makers, researchers and consultants' (Henry et al. 2001, 7). It has 34 member countries including many of the world's wealthiest countries, but also emerging economies like Mexico, Chile and Turkey (OECD n.d.-a). The OECD's current mandate is to support economic growth, promote employment, assist countries in their drive to economic development, and advance world trade and democracy (Kallo 2009). The OECD is not a self-contained entity, but rather a vast network of policy circles and actors, including OECD staff, member countries, policy makers, consultants and researchers (Henry et al. 2001).

The OECD lacks the economic clout of IOs such as the International Monetary Fund or the World Bank and the legislative capacity of regional organizations such as the European Union. Because the OECD's recommendations are non-binding for its member states, it has developed alternative processes, instruments and tools for transmitting and promoting uptake of policy ideas and expert advice. The OECD's policy influence derives from its knowledge production capacities and subsequent

perception of the 'quality of its information and analysis' (Schuller and Vincent-Lancrin 2009, 66). It enacts soft modes of regulation, including publication of comparative data such as educational and social indicators, and peer reviews involving country and thematic reviews (Kallo 2009). Furthermore, its influence derives from demarcating norms and practices that further liberal, market friendly, economic policies (Henry et al. 2001).

Like others who take a constructivist approach to the study of IOs (see Barnett and Finnemore 1999; Ruggie 1998), we take an interest in how 'IOs exercise power as they constitute and construct the social world' (Barnett and Finnemore 1999, 700). As OECD enacts global surveillance of educational developments, it has cast itself as an indispensable actor in educational policy development and a key generator of science-based educational policy (Meyer and Benavot 2013).

The OECD has played a key role in the production and distribution of some of the most significant international educational indicators and assessment tools used in educational policy circles. In this paper, our analysis centres on two: PISA and AHELO. Launched in 1997, PISA is a triennial student assessment of 15-year-olds that has become a global benchmark of student achievement across educational systems. While 32 states participated in the initial PISA in 2000, by 2012, the number had climbed to 64. The OECD emphasises that PISA is not a curriculum-based assessment, but one that assesses students' knowledge and skills in reading, mathematics and science literacy (Meyer and Benavot 2013). A recent OECD publication on the impact of PISA concluded that, 'PISA is becoming an influential element of education policy making processes at the national level' (Breakspear 2012, 27).

OECD's more recently launched AHELO is an assessment that tests university students in their last year in a bachelors programme. The assessment is comprised of four instruments that test students' (a) generic skills, (b) disciplinary knowledge in economics and engineering, (c) contextual information, and finally (d) a value-added strand (Ewell 2012). To date, 17 countries have participated in the AHELO feasibility study; in March 2013, the OECD convened a meeting to exchange findings regarding AHELO's roll out. Should the feasibility study be deemed successful, the OECD envisions that AHELO will become a regular assessment of students enrolled in higher education institutions (see Shahjahan 2013; Shahjahan and Torres 2013).

OECD's mechanisms of global educational governance

Before detailing the three mechanisms that characterise OECD governance processes, we wish to clarify terms and concepts that anchor our theoretical approach. First, we make use of the sociological term 'mechanisms' to identify and group a complex set of OECD governance processes. Second, we use the term 'fixing' ideas to describe OECD governance processes that solidify previously ambiguous concepts among actors. Finally, in discussing the 'diffusion' of ideas, we point to the process through which the OECD spreads or disseminates its ideas among networks and policy circles.

The first mechanism of OECD governance sees the OECD *building on its past successes*. We show how the OECD creates and disseminates internally shared interpretations of the importance of educational benchmarks or student assessment. By building on its past successes, the OECD gains authority as an expert and a reliable resource for evidence-based education policy. These 'successes' play a key role in constructing the OECD as an 'authoritative voice' (Barnett and Finnemore 1999, 710) in

governing education. In the process, the diffusion of OECD's products and tools (here, PISA and AHELO) help embed a shared meaning and an educational assessment culture among participating states.

The second mechanism underlying OECD governance is *assembling knowledge capacity*. In deploying this operational category, we draw on Haas's (1989) work on epistemic communities to analyse the role of experts in the production of PISA and AHELO. As Barnett and Finnemore note, IOs gain autonomy by embodying a 'technical rationality' (1999, 709). We suggest that the OECD created its own epistemic communities for these two assessments to strategically ensure validation of its technical expertise. Drawing on the policy transfer and policy diffusion scholarship, we identify how agents within these epistemic communities transfer ideas through both soft and hard policy transfer (Stone 1999). For our purposes, soft policy transfer encompasses the diffusion of ideas whereas hard policy transfer facilitates the diffusion of policy practices and instruments. In the case of the former, there is room for those agents (such as policy makers and educational experts) involved in policy transfer to adapt ideas to the local context. However, hard policy transfer entails a process of 'copying' practices and instruments that leaves little room for adaptation by local agents (Stone 1999, 55). As we will show in our case studies of PISA and AHELO, a set of micro-practices in educational evaluation travel between supranational and local levels through both diffusion of ideas and direct copying.

The third mechanism tied to the OECD's increasingly influential role in global educational governance is the *deployment of its bureaucratic resources* (Dolowitz and March 1996). The OECD, as a bureaucracy comprised of mostly rich nations, derives power from its 'rational-legal authority and control over expertise' (Barnett and Finnemore 1999, 707). OECD officials are adept at capitalising on their bureaucratic resources in order to achieve the organisation's goals. In our case studies of PISA and AHELO, we illustrate how OECD officials leveraged the organisation's administrative structure to bolster the OECD's position as a think tank in global educational governance.

Our analysis draws on publicly available PISA and AHELO texts such as OECD's website, promotional materials and declassified documents available on the website or provided to us by the OECD. The latter includes PISA and AHELO working papers, meeting minutes, seminar presentations, progress reports and newsletters. These documents not only serve as a rich source of qualitative data for understanding policy process (Merriam 1998), but also highlight the OECD's intentional commitment to transparency about PISA and AHELO. We selected these documents based on their visibility and availability in the PISA debates (during June 1994–March 2004) and AHELO debates (during May 2010–February 2013). To uncover policy mechanisms and understand the players, discourses and decisions made at ground level, we coded PISA and AHELO meeting minutes, newsletters, interviews with various stakeholders and project updates.

PISA and AHELO test production

PISA

Building on past successes

To fully capture and understand how the OECD built on its past successes to set the stage for PISA, we begin our story with the creation of the International Indicators

and Evaluation of Educational Systems (INES) project, established by OECD in 1988. The formation of the INES project reflected a commitment by a group of OECD member countries who 'agreed to work together in the development of a set of international educational indicators covering, in particular, student flows, student outcomes, and costs and resources' (OECD 1988, 59). Through the INES project, the OECD created its 'flagship' educational indicators publication, *Education at a glance* (EAG), first published in 1992.

The publication of EAG reflected the outcome of a complex series of processes involving the ordering of educational knowledge. These processes encompassed the development of taxonomy to categorise educational indicators, the gathering of data for these categories from member states, and the implementation of a quality control process to ensure comparability of the data. As disseminator of EAG, OECD put in place the foundation for an educational system rooted firmly in indicators that measure student outcomes. More significantly, the EAG became a conduit for the OECD to inform educational decisions made by national policy makers and practitioners.

The OECD's authority in governing education was reinforced when the INES project became a permanent component of OECD work in the mid-1990s. With this development, EAG was established as a regular OECD publication that required member states to commit resources to collect 'reliable, valid, and comparable' educational data to be presented in an accessible manner (OECD/INES 1995, 2). The importance that the OECD placed on gathering these educational indicators from its member states contributed to the 'diffusion of an indicator culture within education circles' (OECD/CERI, quoted in Henry et al. 2001, 89). In this way, the EAG became an important vehicle for diffusing and fixing policy ideas about the importance of educational indicators for evidence-based policy and for creating a shared discourse on educational indicators among policy makers and educators. Amid the rising importance of the EAG, the OECD next sought to ensure the reliability of the indicators gathered for this publication, focusing in particular on the quality of its comparative educational outcome data. This new interest would soon legitimise the need for an OECD-produced assessment, manifested as the PISA in the year 2000 when it was first implemented.

Within the INES project, a group of experts organised as 'Network A' were responsible for developing indicators on learning outcomes for EAG. Network A members were tasked with gathering data from various international student assessments but they were frustrated with the quality of the data being produced by the International Association for the Evaluation of Educational Achievement (IEA) suggesting that its data reporting mechanisms were 'too expensive, too slow to report, [did] not cover enough domains, [and did] not involve enough OECD countries' (Owen, Hodgkinson, and Tuijnman 1995, 216). Network A members were also concerned with the fact that the OECD has little influence or control over the testing schedule. In 1995, the OECD Education Committee and Network A members decided to develop their own regular and timely student assessment data to address the gaps that existed in the suite of learning outcome data in the EAG. The stage was set for PISA. More crucially, the OECD very clearly articulated a problem (a gap in educational outcome data) and a clear solution to the problem (the production of its own data). The OECD transformed itself from a gatherer of educational indicators to a producer of educational data. This transformation built on the successful work of the INES project and its publication, EAG.

Assembling knowledge capacity

The OECD also derives its power in global educational governance by producing knowledge that is perceived to be science-based and objective. OECD accumulated this technical expertise by assembling a coalition of supporters and agents during the production stage of the PISA. OECD technical capacity was built through Network A members, expert representatives for their respective ministries of education. Many of these individuals were involved in the International Association for the Evaluation of Educational Achievement (IEA) and, thus, were well connected to a larger network. These members developed the Data Strategy for what would become an international student assessment of 15-year-olds. In doing so, they contracted evaluation work to an agency or consortium of agencies through a tendering process in order to collect national data from participating states (OECD 1995). In calling for proposals for independent contractors to undertake the technical work of PISA, the OECD casts itself as an objective actor. However, every aspect of the contractor's work is scrutinised by the OECD bureaucrats as represented by the OECD Secretariat.

Crucial to the success of the production of the assessment was the selection of the prime contractor who would ensure that all necessary technical requirements were met, including: Framework Development, Instrument Development, Sampling, Survey Procedures and Operations, Data Verification, Scaling and Preparing Data Product, Project Structure, and Management (OECD 1997a). The Board of Participating Countries (BPC), formed from the Network A INES project, selected the Australian Council for Educational Research (ACER) as the prime contractor, and the locus of knowledge in the educational assessment field shifted away from the IEA to the OECD. This shift was monumental in the close-knit educational assessment community. Since the IEA's formation in 1958, it had trained some of the world's leading statisticians and psychometricians in international testing (Bottani and Vrignaud 2005) and prided itself on being an independent educational research organisation (Postlethwaite 1966, 356). More significantly, the OECD, via ACER, gained the knowledge capacity to create these international student assessments, and as will be evident in the case of AHELO, was able to extend this knowledge capacity to the production of higher education indicators.

Not only did the OECD gain in technical knowledge capacity, it also built the necessary subject matter knowledge capacity during the production stages of the PISA. In defining the subject matter to be tested, OECD's functional expert groups fixed and diffused ideas about what 15-year-olds should be learning. These expert groups, 'link[ed] the policy objectives specified by the Board of Participating Countries with substantive and technical expertise' and 'establish[ed] consensus on subject matter and technical issues among countries' (OECD 1997b, 60). More importantly, members of these expert groups were effective in mobilising support and promoting the PISA within their larger networks of national and international experts.

The production of the PISA involved developing domain frameworks in reading, mathematics and science, and formulating the questions that would measure students' knowledge in these domains. These frameworks were important transmitters of the priorities of globalised educational discourse in their framing of student learning, not in terms of curricular knowledge but in terms of literacy skills (OECD 1998) – referring to a student's ability to apply their knowledge and skills in key subject areas (see for example, OECD 2006a, 2010a). Not only did they enfold assumptions about student learning, but the domain frameworks were also conduits of hard policy transfer in

their stipulation of the types of test items that should be written for each domain. These experts were advised to follow a specific process to be replicated by each participating country: each test item was to be written so as to assess a set of explicit tasks. For example: the ability to grasp scientific ideas was assessed based on the interpretation of a scientific text; the ability to retrieve information from a text or from a graph was assessed based on answers to a set of questions related to a newspaper article; and mathematical problem-solving ability was assessed through application of a certain form of computation to a problem (OECD 2000). Through this form of educational transfer, the practice of writing curriculum-based test items was supplanted by non-curricular and skills-based test items.

The OECD assembles its knowledge capacity by reinforcing a globalised educational discourse that values scientific-based evidence over other forms of educational knowledge. At the same time, the OECD instils micro-practices tied to the construction of a specific type of assessment which aims to measure what the OECD defines as student 'literacy' skills. Even as they appear to be innocuous, these micro-practices pre-determine a literacy- or competency-based curriculum that furthers legitimates OECD expertise.

Deploying bureaucratic resources

Finally, the OECD's influence in global educational governance is strengthened by its ability to deploy its administrative structure to achieve its goals. When the OECD adopted production of indicators as 'a core activity' in the mid-1990s (Henry et al. 2001, 89), it also created a governance structure. Within the OECD's Directorate for Education, Employment, Labour, and Social Affairs, OECD officials established a Statistical and Indicators Division that combined the resources of both the Centre for Educational Research and Innovation (CERI) and the Education Committee. The OECD created the necessary bureaucratic structure to buttress its knowledge production role in education.

Through a highly effective organisational process, the OECD guarantees the high quality standards and robustness of its assessment results during the production stages. During the early stages of PISA production, a committee comprised of members of INES project's Network A was created. This committee was initially known as the Board of Participating Countries (BPC) and was chaired by the American representative, Eugene Owen (OECD 1997b). The BPC was responsible for selecting the prime contractor and overseeing its work. As the PISA became more central to the OECD's education policy work, the task of governing PISA was delinked from the INES project and relocated to the OECD's Education Directorate. By 2005, the BPC had become the PISA Governing Board and was largely composed of key educational decision makers from participating countries (OECD 2004). This re-organisation centrally located the PISA within OECD's institutional framework, aligning it more closely with member states' educational priorities.

AHELO

Building on past successes

At the 2006 OECD Education Ministers' meeting, Angel Gurria, the Secretary-General of the OECD, pointed to the 'urgent requirement for reform' in higher education and

appealed to Education Ministers for a 'mandate for a "PISA for higher education" led by the OECD' (OECD 2006b, 2). Education Ministers responded to the Secretary-General's appeal by giving OECD the green light to implement a feasibility study of an assessment for higher education learning outcomes that 'buil[t] on the success of the PISA' (5). Buoyed by its success at producing an assessment of 15-year-old learners, OECD could readily claim that it was 'best positioned [among other IOs] to provide Member countries with policy-oriented comparative assessment tools' in higher education (OECD n.d.-b). This rhetoric of past success in the development of an international assessment tool is echoed in other OECD forums; its website presents the organisation as an authoritative knowledge provider in education by highlighting its 40 years of experience (OECD 2012a).

In order to instil shared meaning and vision for the production of learning outcomes in higher education,[1] the OECD problematised a higher education 'information gap' that needed to be filled by data collected through reliable and objective measures of teaching and learning outcomes (OECD 2007). However, AHELO's creators acknowledged significant barriers to obtaining these indicators at the 'system' level given the diversity of higher educational institutions and the difficulty bounding a representative sample. In light of this, AHELO creators opted to assess students at the institutional level. The challenge was how to persuade higher education institutions to buy in. The experts who convened in April 2007 to define the contours of AHELO clearly understood the need for developing a shared discourse on an appropriate set of measures in higher education while simultaneously underlining the need for reliability and robustness of assessment methods (see OECD 2007, 3–8). Given the OECD's past achievements in producing successful educational indicators, higher educational institutions would likely participate in a feasibility study that implemented the highest quality standards and which guaranteed robustness and confidentiality of results.

In its discursive practices, the OECD further reinforces the importance of a reliable measure for higher educational learning outcomes by distinguishing AHELO from international rankings such as the Times Higher Education World University Rankings or Shanghai Jiao Tong University's Academic Ranking of World Universities (see also Shahjahan 2013; Shahjahan and Torres 2013). In public presentations, OECD officials describe these international rankings as 'biased towards input factors and research' (Lalancette 2010). On its website, the OECD notes that '[t]he narrow range of criteria used in university rankings creates a distorted vision of educational success and fail[s] to capture the essential elements of an education: teaching and learning' (OECD n.d.-b). In contrast, AHELO is presented as a measure founded on scientific, objective and reliable knowledge. Karine Tremblay, AHELO project manager, echoes the OECD commitment to evidence-based policy: 'The OECD believes in evidence-based policy and practice: diagnosis as a basis for change and improvement' (AHELO 2009, 1). The legitimacy of OECD's knowledge outputs, rooted in AHELO, hinges on the success of the feasibility study and the quality of the data obtained. As experts noted in the first AHELO meeting, 'getting the "science for the assessment" right would critically determine the credibility of the exercise' (OECD 2007, 8). These discursive practices demonstrate that, during the early stages of test production, the OECD actively embeds a shared meaning of its vision to create a 'space of equivalence focused on student learning outcomes' in higher education (Shahjahan and Torres 2013).

Assembling knowledge capacity

The OECD does not solely build support based on its own expertise but also assembles its policy prowess and knowledge capacity through the recruitment of 'international experts' from among members of policy think tanks and consultants. It garners this policy prowess by emphasising the vast scale and sheer numbers of people that constitute its epistemic community. For instance, in a recent feasibility report, the OECD (2012) notes that while over 100 people are operationally involved in AHELO, up to 300 are participating in various groups (e.g. expert groups, stakeholder groups, and so on), and 250 leaders, 10,000 faculty and 40,000 students will be involved in AHELO testing (8).

Mirroring the PISA production process, the OECD built an epistemic community that encompassed both technical and subject matter expertise to support AHELO. In terms of technical know-how, ACER, which has also led the PISA consortium, was put in charge of AHELO overall assessment design, synergies across various strands and management of the project. ACER leads an international consortium guided by the AHELO General National Experts and the OECD Secretariat (OECD 2012).

While PISA was concerned with building knowledge capacity in reading, science and mathematics subject matter domains, the OECD faces the daunting task of building knowledge capacity for AHELO's four key strands: (1) generic skills strand; (2) discipline-specific strand; (3) contextual strand; and (4) value-added strand (OECD 2012b). This enormous task requires multiple networks and a coalition of supporters for the development and implementation of each strand.

In constructing test instruments for the economics and engineering disciplinary AHELO strands, the OECD assembles the necessary disciplinary expertise so it can legitimately ascertain which areas of student knowledge should be tested and how to measure student learning outcomes. For example, based on its experience in developing the economics strand, the OECD is able to assert that 'it is possible to define discipline-specific learning outcomes internationally' (OECD 2012b, 117). In building its knowledge capacity via its economics epistemic community, the OECD generated consensus on the economic concepts to be tested (key economic concepts, microeconomic and macroeconomic concepts). In addition to assessing student subject matter knowledge, the AHELO economics assessments evaluate other learning outcomes such as the application of economics concepts to 'real world problems', 'the ability to communicate with specialists and nonspecialists', and 'the ability to acquire independent learning skills' (OECD 2011). Here, the OECD organises student knowledge in terms of specific competencies not traditionally associated with disciplinary knowledge or research but, rather, more aligned with work competencies. As the OECD notes in its recent feasibility report, the economics strand assesses 'above content-knowledge' and focuses on the 'application and use of the concepts and "language of economics"' (OECD 2012b, 118). Yet, the impetus and templates (including test questions) for AHELO's discipline-specific strands derive mainly from a core set of OECD member states: EU countries, the US or Japan (Shahjahan 2013).

In creating the generic skills strand, the OECD did not follow its established practice of initially developing a framework. This first step was deemed unnecessary in this case since OECD was adopting a pre-existing instrument with its own 'underlying theoretical underpinning' (OECD 2012b, 145); the instrument was based on the US Collegiate Learning Assessment (CLA) created by the Council for Aid to Education.[2] AHELO's creators presumed that an adaptive approach would be less time consuming

and less costly (Ewell 2012). However, since the performance tasks were designed with an American student in mind, their translation and adaptation proved difficult. To correct these problems, AHELO's creators added multiple choice questions and developed an assessment framework (OECD 2012a, 6). Had the generic skills strand followed the usual framework development process, these major revisions could have been avoided (Ewell 2012). Instead of developing adequate knowledge capacity to build the generic skills component, the OECD opted to deploy a form of hard policy transfer that was not effective in ensuring the overall quality of the assessment but was fraught with challenges (see OECD 2012b).

Deploying bureaucratic resources

The OECD is fully cognisant of the strength of its bureaucratic structure. It justifies its role in the production of AHELO by claiming that it 'possesses the institutional framework necessary to oversee international comparative work' (OECD 2006b, 6). As we saw with PISA, the OECD cannot effectively exert its influence as a knowledge producer of higher education indicators without deploying its institutional framework and governance structure. Given the vast nature of the AHELO network, the production of AHELO not only represents a monumental task in scientific breakthroughs in assessment, but also tests the limits of collaboration across global contexts. To this end, the OECD recognises that it will need to ensure its bureaucratic resources enable a 'unique governance arrangement' through which AHELO is 'jointly steered by governments, HEIs and agencies through the Programme for Institutional Management in Higher Education (IMHE) Governing Board' (OECD 2010a, 12–13). However, the OECD also ensures that decision-making power remains centralised by stipulating that once the feasibility study is completed, decisions pertaining to the future of AHELO be made by the Education Policy Committee, which is responsible for the overall strategic direction of the OECD's work on education (OECD 2010a).

In contrast to the PISA, which was initially conceived and produced by the INES Network project and then brought into the heart of the OECD governance structure a few years later, AHELO is centred within the OECD institutional framework. The technical nature of the project has led the IMHE Governing Board and the Education Policy Committee to delegate decisions on the methods, timing and principles of the AHELO feasibility study to an AHELO Group of National Experts (GNE). The AHELO GNE is expected to meet about twice a year over the life of the project; the OECD provides the GNE with Secretariat services. A number of ad-hoc groups and experts play a more indirect role in the steering of the AHELO feasibility study through the sharing of expertise, dialogue or advice. Likewise, the Tuning Association has been contracted to convene academics from across the globe in order to reflect on definitions of expected or intended learning outcomes in economics and engineering.

Finally, a Stakeholders' Consultative Group (SCG) has been established to discuss and reflect on the unfolding of the AHELO feasibility study and its potential longer-term impact. The SCG is unique to AHELO and meant to iteratively gauge reactions to roll out of AHELO products and documents. The OECD leaves some flexibility as to how it will tap into the SCG, noting that stakeholder participation 'will depend on its possibility, will and capacity' and that stakeholder engagement will be influenced by which stakeholders are 'deemed representative for the higher education sector' (OECD 2009, 5).

Conclusion

Through comparative analysis of two international education assessment tools, we demonstrate that the OECD deploys various governance mechanisms during the production stages of PISA and AHELO to acquire the legitimate power to define what counts in education. These mechanisms include: (1) building on past OECD successes; (2) assembling knowledge capacity; and (3) deploying bureaucratic resources. By analysing the stages of assessment production, we illustrate the specific ways in which educational transfer takes place.

While we have noted several commonalities between the PISA and AHELO, we also point to important differences. Whereas with PISA, the OECD was a relative novice in the international student assessment field, by the time it launched AHELO, it had become a seasoned expert in this field. This confidence is manifested in the organisation of AHELO during the production phase – from the coalition of supporters to the governance structure. A cornerstone element of the PISA is its assessment of literacy skills. In contrast, AHELO shifts focus to assessment of higher levels of learning. Underpinning AHELO is the assessment of learning outcomes from content-based knowledge in economics and engineering as well as the generic skills of graduates. However, despite these distinctions, both assessments are ultimately tools used by policy makers to improve the quality of their human capital and address employers' demand for skilled workers.

The creators of AHELO faced several financial and technical challenges not faced by the PISA creators. Recent AHELO reports (OECD 2012b, 2013) reveal that the process of constructing AHELO was fraught with challenges. In particular, despite deploying bureaucratic resources to ensure the success of the AHELO feasibility study, OECD still had to contend with the financial constraints of OECD member states. Whereas PISA was developed during a period of relative global economic stability and prosperity, AHELO emerged amid severe economic recession, impacting the availability of funding for the AHELO project (OECD 2013, 157). Further, the creators of AHELO did not have adequate knowledge capacity to build the generic skills component and faced several challenges in constructing the instrument. Namely, tensions arose between the different stakeholders involved in constructing instruments. For example, there continues to be debates about the relevance of assessing generic skills outside of disciplinary contexts (OECD 2012b). In future publications, we hope to explore the negotiated compromises that characterised the development of the AHELO assessment.

We suggest that the early stages of test production by IOs are significant sites for legitimating and enacting the global governance of education that has been often overlooked in the literature. As such, our analysis suggests the need for more theoretical and empirical research on the complex ways IOs legitimate and enact global educational governance as they produce large-scale international assessment tools. First, such studies would illuminate the complexity of the production of assessment tools that is fraught with tensions and contradictions, while simultaneously revealing that the production of these tools are important sites for fixing meaning about 'learning' in education. Second, our analysis suggests that the assessment production process is fragile (often with lots of push back and criticisms); hence we draw attention to the agentive role of IOs involved in the policy production process. IOs justify, legitimise and sustain the production process using an arsenal of past experiences, epistemic networks and bureaucratic structures. Third, the early stages of the assessment production process raise questions about the epistemic origins of ideas, and the adoption, translation and incorporation of these ideas into global templates. This prompts us to interrogate how the transfer of ideas is

influenced by economic and epistemic dependencies that pervade the global policy arena and undergird the universalising models of education that are disseminated via IOs (Shahjahan 2013). In short, we recommend moving beyond the plentiful methodological critiques and impact studies of assessment tools in the existing literature to critically examine the geopolitics of producing global education policy.

Given the global interest in using tools such as PISA and AHELO to measure and enhance educational outcomes, our analysis raises many questions about the role of standardised assessment and learning outcome tools for educational quality improvement. For instance, it raises questions about the relationship and tradeoffs between quality and autonomy, the importance of local knowledge in a highly connected world, and the role and reach of international assessment tools within local contexts. The early stages of test production vis-à-vis IOs are not simply techno-rational processes, but important 'global classrooms' for constructing, negotiating, disseminating and legitimising what counts as knowledge and learning in a competitive global economy. We suggest that these growing 'global classrooms' are important sites of study for scholars interested in the global governance of education.

Notes

1. It is beyond the scope of this article to provide a thorough analysis of the OECD's official account for the AHELO rationale. For in-depth critical policy analyses of these rationales, please refer to Shahjahan and Torres (2013) and Shahjahan (2013).
2. The CLA gained significant attention in the United States when analysis of 2011 CLA results found that US graduates were failing to master higher-order cognitive skills (Arum and Roska 2011).

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